

Any AI that dosent harm the environment

Posted by u/Dazzling_Rutabaga837 • 0 points • 3 comments

I want to improve my social skills so I can talk to people and I want to use AI to help me with that, I used to use ChatGPT but it harms the environment

Comments

u/Koooooj • 1 points • 2026-01-01 02:43 UTC

Basically all consumption comes at some environmental cost, typically in the form of using energy of which some portion comes from burning fossil fuels (or increases the demand for fossil fuels by using up capacity of renewables that could have otherwise powered those other loads).

AI has a lot of ethical issues around intellectual property and threatens to displace large numbers of workers, many of whom created the very IP that AI rips off. As a result it tends to be easy to run articles criticizing AI even if the truth behind the article is shaky at best.

When it comes to the actual environmental cost of AI it's all in energy: electricity to power the computers that generate responses, then energy to cool that resulting waste heat. This could be in the form of closed-loop radiators, but it takes **less** energy to use evaporative towers (like the big stacks people associate with nuclear power plants). People **should** be happy that AI datacenters are opting for the lower energy consumption method of cooling since that means fewer greenhouse gasses, but instead you get articles complaining about the wasted water. To be clear, it's using resources either way, but it's a kind of foolish line to draw in the sand. The water use pales in comparison to most other uses and you have to do tricky things like listing the xillions of gallons that **all** AI data centers use as a way to come up with a number people can't really comprehend and just assume must be big compared to other water uses.

<Disclaimer: I've made a good-faith attempt to get decently accurate numbers below. They should all be the right relative magnitudes. Don't cite these without doing your own digging, but hopefully they make the point well.>

For example, say you give an AI a query that takes 10 seconds at 500W to reply to. That's 5 kW or 0.0014 kWh or about 1/100 of a cent. If the energy to serve this query came fossil fuels you're looking at around 1 gram of fuel, probably a little less. That heat could then be removed by evaporating about 2.2 grams of water. Note that about 5-10 grams of water probably went into the production of that gram of fuel.

By comparison, if you hop into a 2015 Honda Civic that gets 35 mpg and drive 10 miles to a restaurant then that's .29 gallons of gas, or about 800 grams of gasoline, which probably took around 8 kg of water to extract and refine. Then if you eat half a kilogram of food that might be a few hundred kg of

water for a vegetable-heavy meal, up to several thousand for meat. Fuel use for the food similarly varies with food type, with vegetables being perhaps a kg of fuel for 500 g of vegetables, or beef being more like 15-50 kg.

If you want to avoid AI because of all the IP theft or its threat to turn the economy on its head then that's a perfectly reasonable stance to take. You could compare AI vendors for how they stack up here, but it seems all the big players are taking the route of "use everything on the internet, say it's OK, and lobby the government to agree." I like their chances.

On the other hand, if your only concern is environmental then perhaps reevaluate if eliminating AI use is the biggest impact you can have on your environmental footprint. For most people simply eating less meat will be one of the biggest impacts they can have.

u/DMmeNiceTitties • 1 points • 2026-01-01 02:21 UTC

There's real people on the internet you can practice with and not a machine with preprogrammed answers.

u/mugenhunt • 1 points • 2026-01-01 02:20 UTC

All AI is harmful for the environment because of the excessive amount of electricity it requires.

u/zowietremendously • 1 points • 2026-01-01 02:19 UTC

Talk to people if you want to improve your people skills.